Twelve Things to Notice About the Help Your Wife Gets in a Day

Everyday things to notice and write down, from morning to bedtime, with no diagnosing.

You've helped your wife for so long that much of it has stopped feeling like help. It's just the day. This guide walks through that day in twelve parts and, for each, says what to notice and what to write down. If she's in the hospital as you read this, write it from her last ordinary days at home.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. Write the help you give or see given, and when you've seen it. Where you haven't seen something, write “not observed.” How much help she needs, and what kind of care that points to, are questions for her care team. The areas below follow the Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide, which asks families to go through the kinds of care needed one by one; the wording about what to write down is ours.

Morning

1 Getting out of bed [1]

NOTICE What she holds on the way from lying down to standing, and whether you steady her, lift, or wait nearby.

WRITE DOWN The help you give at that moment: a hand, standing by, or doing it for her.

2 Washing and bathing [1]

NOTICE Whether she starts on her own or when reminded, what you set out for her, and the point where you step in.

WRITE DOWN What she does herself, and the part someone else does.

3 Dressing and grooming [1]

NOTICE Choosing clothes, buttons and shoes, hair and teeth.

WRITE DOWN Each part, and whether she does it alone, with a prompt, or with your hands helping.

4 Using the bathroom [1]

NOTICE Getting there, managing clothing, cleaning up, and whether someone goes with her.

WRITE DOWN The help given, as plain fact, with the time of day when you've seen it.

Through the day

5 Meals and eating [1] [2]

NOTICE Who cooks, who brings the plate, whether she begins eating on her own or once someone reminds her, and any help with cutting or lifting food.

WRITE DOWN An ordinary day's meals: who made each one, and what help she had eating it.

6 Medications [1] [2]

NOTICE Who sets the pills out, who reminds her, and who checks that they were taken.

WRITE DOWN What you do, step by step. Change nothing; questions go to her pharmacist or the prescriber.

7 Moving around the house [1]

NOTICE How she gets from room to room, what she holds or uses, and the places where you walk beside her.

WRITE DOWN The cane, walker, rail or arm she uses, and where.

8 Reminders, standing by and time on her own [3]

NOTICE The things she does herself once someone says it's time or stays close, and the stretches of the day she spends by herself.

WRITE DOWN The tasks where your part is a word or your presence, and the hours she's alone as you've seen them. Supervision is a question for her care team: write what you saw and ask.

Evening and night

9 Getting ready for bed [1]

NOTICE Changing, washing, the evening pills, getting into bed, and which of those someone helps with.

WRITE DOWN The evening routine in order, with who does what.

10 The night [1]

NOTICE Whether she gets up, and whether you get up with her.

WRITE DOWN The nights you've seen it, the time, and what help she had. Only what you saw.

Across the whole day

11 Making herself understood

NOTICE Glasses, hearing aids, how she tells you what she wants, and who does the talking at appointments.

WRITE DOWN What helps her follow a conversation and take part in it.

12 Who helps, and what's yours [4]

NOTICE Everyone who does something for her in a week, the days and times they come, and how much of the day is yours.

WRITE DOWN Who does what and when, and what you can realistically keep doing.

When a note isn't enough

These notes are about ordinary days. If something you notice about your wife's health concerns you, tell her nurse or her doctor instead of saving it for the page. The National Institute on Aging's advice to families concerned about a person's physical or mental health is a visit to a health care provider.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of this means, how much help your wife needs, or what kind of care or setting fits her. Her care team does that, and your notes show them the part of her day they can't see from the hospital.

Ready for the next step?

You've gone through an ordinary day and written down the help in it. The care interview covers every area of your wife's daily life, including the parts that don't show up at home, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
2. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
3. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Outcome and Assessment Information Set Version E1 (OASIS-E1) All Items, effective 01/01/2025
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.